caste, whose population rose from 10,000 at the turn of the 20th century to around 1,00,000 at the turn of the 21st.[15] The first historical record of this community dates back to the 17th century when they were documented as salt traders in south India.[16] In the 18th century, they were identified as traders of pearls, arrack, cloth and rice in places like Sri Lanka and Calcutta. Around 1808, they established their first banking firms in Malacca, followed by Penang and Singapore.[17] These firms served small Indian and Chinese traders by providing medium- and long-term credit. The Malaya region was emerging as an important junction in the global trading system, especially in the lucrative opium trade between India and China. By the middle of the 19th century, the bulk of this trade in Singapore passed through Chettiar hands.[18]

The stunning rise of Chettiar wealth would occur in the early 20th century thanks to the tea, rice and rubber fields of Sri Lanka, Burma, and Malaya respectively. In these places, the Chettiars formed a unique migratory chain that financed the expanding frontiers of the cultivation of these products. This involved agents, associations and a certain amount of asceticism.[19] Chettiar families would send out agents to remote places and occupy the position of the local village moneylender. Almost all the big villages of lower Burma, for instance, had a financial connection with Chettinad through these agents. Agents were young men who worked for three years and tried to maximize their returns from lending. After accumulating profits over several terms, they would become independent and have their own agents. Chettiar associations would coordinate these activities in different places, especially the setting of interest rates that ranged from 10–40 per cent per annum. Money was rarely spent in the places the Chettiars migrated to as they practised a life of austere living. Savings were either re-invested into business or remitted back to India as profits. Remittances would finance the upkeep of the Shaivite Chettinad temples and the construction of grand mansions and palaces that still survive. Chettiar migration, therefore, closely followed the pattern of the Great Indian Migration Wave as it was male-dominated, semi-permanent and remittance-based.